TENNESSEE

The Volunteer State



Nashville in the 1930s was a city of contradictions—grand limestone courthouse steps and unpaved back roads, Grand Ole Opry broadcasts crackling through radio sets while families scraped through the tail end of the Depression. It was in this Nashville, in the North End neighborhood near Jefferson Street, that a small family chicken shack run by Thornton Prince and his family quietly gave birth to one of the most iconic dishes in American food history.

The story, as Nashville has always told it, begins with revenge. Thornton Prince was known around the neighborhood as a man who loved two things: a good time and fried chicken. After one late night out, the story goes, his furious girlfriend decided to teach him a lesson by dousing his Sunday chicken in a punishing amount of cayenne pepper and spice, expecting the heat to be his punishment. Instead, Prince loved it. He refined the recipe, built it into something deliberate and layered, and eventually opened Prince's Hot Chicken Shack—a restaurant that would endure for decades and seed an entire culinary movement.

Jefferson Street in those years was the beating heart of Black Nashville—a vibrant corridor of jazz clubs, barbershops, beauty parlors, and restaurants that thrived during the era of segregation, when Black-owned businesses served Black communities with a richness and creativity that broader Nashville rarely acknowledged. Prince's sat comfortably in that world, drawing a loyal neighborhood crowd who knew that the chicken arrived on white bread with pickle chips for a reason—the bread was there to catch the drippings of that impossibly red, spiced fry oil, and the pickles were there to cut through the heat with a clean, cool snap.

The technique was specific and unapologetic. Chicken pieces fried low and slow until cooked through, then painted with a paste of lard, cayenne, and a careful measure of other spices—a formula the Prince family kept close for generations. The heat built slowly, starting at the lips, moving to the back of the throat, arriving eventually as a full, satisfying burn that somehow made the next bite more necessary than the last. It was addictive in the most honest sense of the word.

For decades, hot chicken remained a beloved local secret, known deeply in North Nashville and barely at all beyond it. It wasn't until the 1990s and early 2000s, when food writers and chefs began documenting Southern culinary traditions with new seriousness, that the wider world caught up to what Jefferson Street had known for sixty years. Today, hot chicken festivals draw thousands to Nashville each summer, and versions of the dish appear on menus from Los Angeles to London—but none of them quite carry the weight of the original, born from a neighborhood, a family, and one spectacularly backfired act of spite.

When you make this dish, you are pulling on a long, proud thread. Get your oil hot, don't rush the spice paste, and serve it the traditional way—on white bread, with pickles. The heat will build exactly as it should, and you will understand immediately why Nashville never let this one go.

FRIED CHICKEN WITH SPICY NASHVILLE PASTE

Every fiery, glorious bite of Nashville Hot Chicken is proof that bold hands and bolder spice can turn a simple bird into a legend.

Yield: 4 servings

INGREDIENTS

CHICKEN & BRINE

- 3 lb. bone-in, skin-on chicken
- 2 cups buttermilk
- 1 Tbsp hot sauce
- 1 tsp salt

DREDGE

- 2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp black pepper
- 1 tsp paprika
- Vegetable or peanut oil, for frying

HOT PASTE

- ½ cup frying oil
- 2 Tbsp cayenne pepper
- 1 Tbsp brown sugar
- 1 tsp paprika
- 1 tsp garlic powder
- Salt and pepper, to taste

TO SERVE

- Slices of soft white bread
- Dill pickle chips

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Brine the chicken*: In a large bowl, whisk together the buttermilk, hot sauce, and salt. Add the chicken, turning to coat, and cover. Refrigerate at least 2 hours, or overnight. The buttermilk brine seasons the meat deep down and keeps it juicy under the hot fry.
2. *Dredge*: In a shallow dish, whisk together the flour, salt, pepper, and paprika. Lift each piece of chicken from the brine, letting the excess drip off, and press it firmly into the flour until well coated on all sides. Set the coated pieces on a rack and let them rest 15 minutes so the coating sets—this helps it cling instead of sloughing off in the oil.
3. *Heat the oil*: Pour about 2 inches of oil into a heavy, deep skillet or Dutch oven and heat over medium-high to 350°F (175°C). A pinch of flour dropped in should sizzle steadily.
4. *Fry the chicken*: Working in batches so you don't crowd the pan, lower the chicken in skin-side down and fry, turning once, until deep golden and cooked through, 12–15 minutes total depending on size. The thickest piece should reach 165°F (74°C) at the bone. Drain on a wire rack and keep the fry oil—you'll want a little for the paste.
5. *Make the hot paste*: In a heatproof bowl, whisk together the hot frying oil, cayenne, brown sugar, paprika, garlic powder, and salt and pepper, to taste. Whisking the spices into the warm fat blooms them into a glossy, brick-red paste. Stand back—the cayenne is potent. You may need a mask.
6. *Coat and serve*: Brush the hot paste generously over each piece of fried chicken, turning to cover it completely. Serve the traditional way: on a slice of soft white bread to catch the drippings, topped with dill pickle chips.

